RURAL & LANDSCAPE PLANNING

The Scope of Rural Planning

- 3rd lecture -

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Lecture outline

Key questions:

- What is rural planning?
- Evolution of rural planning

  >> Limitations and critique
- Rural planning: its scope and instruments
- Reframing rural planning

Key takeaways

What is planning?

- Planning is a **comprehensive term**

- Internationally, it embodies various:

  - traditions/models
  - knowledge from various disciplines (architecture, engineering, social sciences)
  - systems of governance (cf. US vs China)

- Almost everywhere, planning is considered as:
  - a contested political activity – reconciling often conflicting public goals and concerns

What is planning?

Some basic definitions:

- "Planning is concerned with **deliberately** achieving some **objective** and it proceeds by assembling actions into an **orderly sequence**."
  (Peter Hall 2002)

- Planning activity is about "making places better for **people**."
  (Patsy Healey, 2010)

- Planning "as a means by which **society collectively decides** what … change should be like and tries to achieve that vision by a **mix of means**."
  (Yvonne Rydin, 2011)

These definitions would seem to apply equally to urban and rural places

What is planning?

Is planning different across urban and rural places?

- **No:** Planning as a procedure or process, planning toolkits
- **Yes:** substantive focus, topics/themes, outcomes, scale, social norms, political cultures

The rural landscape

The rural as …	
A playground …	… as a place of consumption for new second home-owners, tourists, food consumers
A dumping ground …	… for controversial unwanted land-uses (e.g. waste incinerators, prisons)
A post carbon landscape …	… a site for the (often contested) deployment of renewable energy – wind farms, solar farms, biomass
A resource sink …	… a site for extracting resources, often with short term 'boomtown' effects and limited long term re-investment in rural futures
A cultural heritage repository …	… tied into perceptions of rural 'authenticity' and nostalgia, cultural landscapes and the commodification of place
A food basket …	… as agriculture remains as a dominant land-use and function of rural places
A provider of ecosystem services …	… whereby ecosystems provide functions and services essential to human wellbeing, from recreation to flood alleviation or carbon storage
A social space …	… at the scale of everyday life, where people live and interact, often characterised by strong place attachment

Gallent & Scott, 2017

Emerging trends: dispersed settlements

Emerging trends: clean energy

Emerging trends: clean energy

Spain

China

Emerging trends: changing rural economy

Emerging trends: infrastructural development

High Speed Rail – HS2

Emerging trends: growth of data centres

Echelon gets go-ahead for €500m data centre in Arklow

Bord Pleanála dismisses appeal against planning permission for 100MW centre

Fri, Jul 19, 2019, 11:45

Colin Gleeson

Apple scraps plan for €850 million data centre in Athenry

Minister says decision shows need to make planning process more efficient

Thu, May 10, 2018, 09:12 | Updated: Thu, May 10, 2018, 10:26

Charlie Taylor , Peter Hamilton

Video | Images

Apple's planned data centre in Athenry has been scrapped

What is rural planning?

Rural planning is primarily a Global North project

>> Rural planning
>> Rural development (social and economic)

Global South

>> Rural development focus

What is rural planning?

- **Internationally** – variation in land-use governance, rural planning regimes and political cultures

- **Typology** (according to Gallent et al., 2003)

>> Cohesive regulatory regimes:
e.g., the Netherlands, Sweden, regulation and compliance

>> Laissez-faire regimes - importance of family associations (e.g., large farming landlords) rather than welfare state:
e.g., southern Europe + Ireland

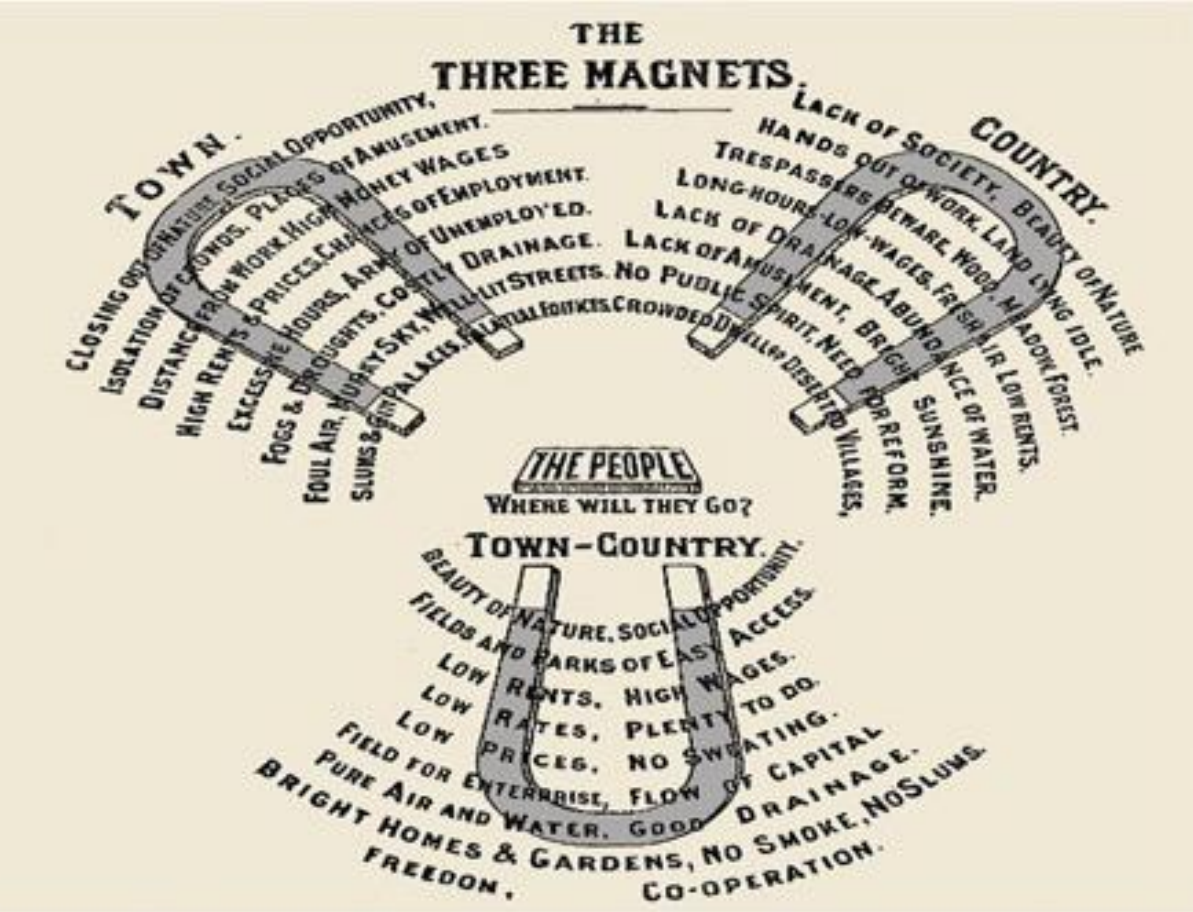
>> Divisive cultures (urban vs. rural) and unstable regimes:
e.g., UK, US

The evolution of rural planning

"While rural concerns were central to the emergence of planning in the last century, during the second half of the 20th century planning theory and practice have been dominated by urban challenges, with an increasingly unimaginative **rural planning regime driven largely by a dominant agricultural agenda.**"

(Scott et al., 2019, p. 1)

The evolution of rural planning:
The British tradition of town and country planning (1900s)



Ebenezer Howard:

The concept of 'Garden City'

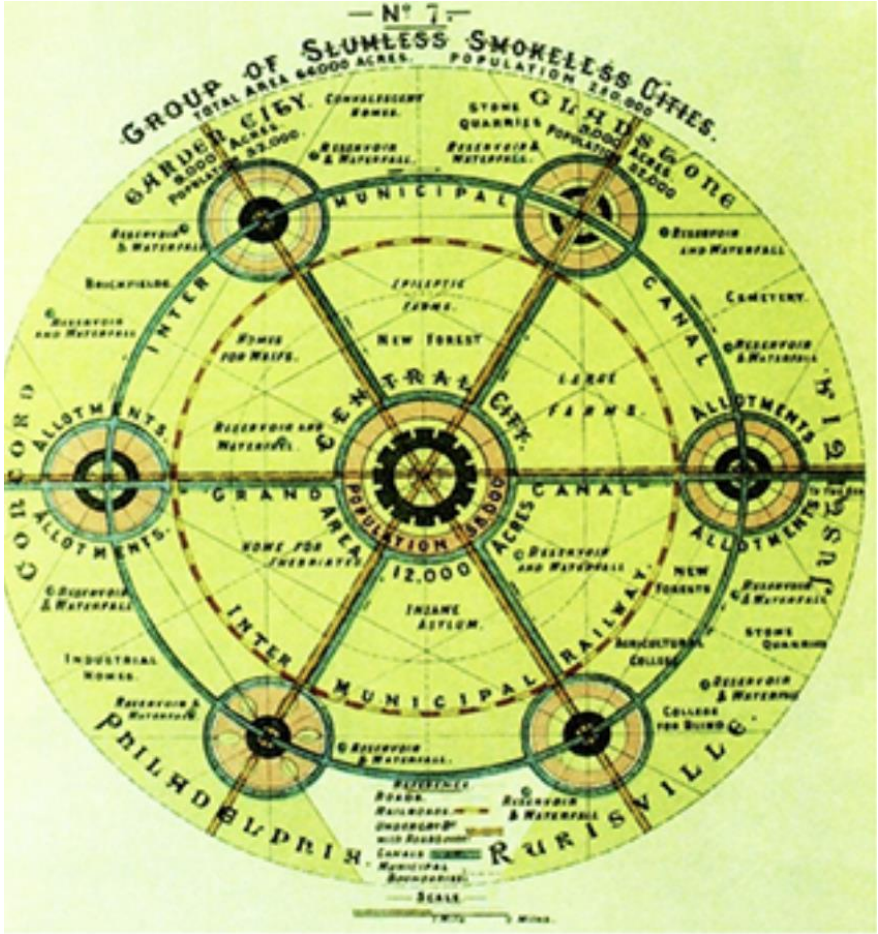
The evolution of rural planning:
The British tradition of town and country planning (1900s)

Welwyn Garden City

Landscape

Letchworth Garden City

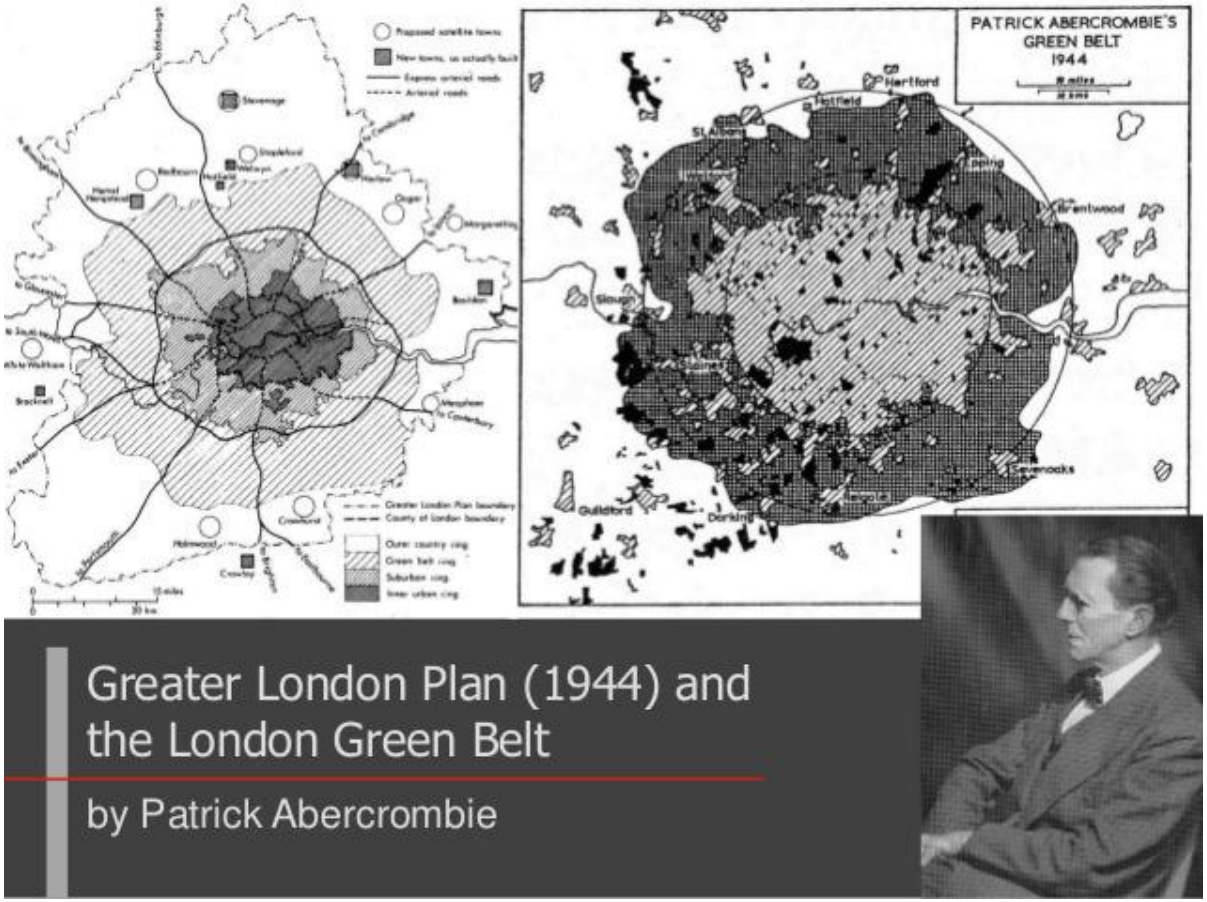
Landscape



Ebenezer Howard:

***Garden Cities of Tomorrow* (1902)**

The evolution of rural planning:
The British tradition of town and country planning (1900s)



Patrick Abercrombie:

Greenbelts:

- Rural preservation
- Urban containment, i.e., prevention from urban sprawl
- Prevention from people 'colonising' the countryside as England's greatest monument

The evolution of rural planning:
The British tradition of town and country planning (1900s)

National parks:

- Preserving sublime landscapes
- Access to the countryside

The evolution of rural planning:
US regionalists (1930s), US rural megaprojects

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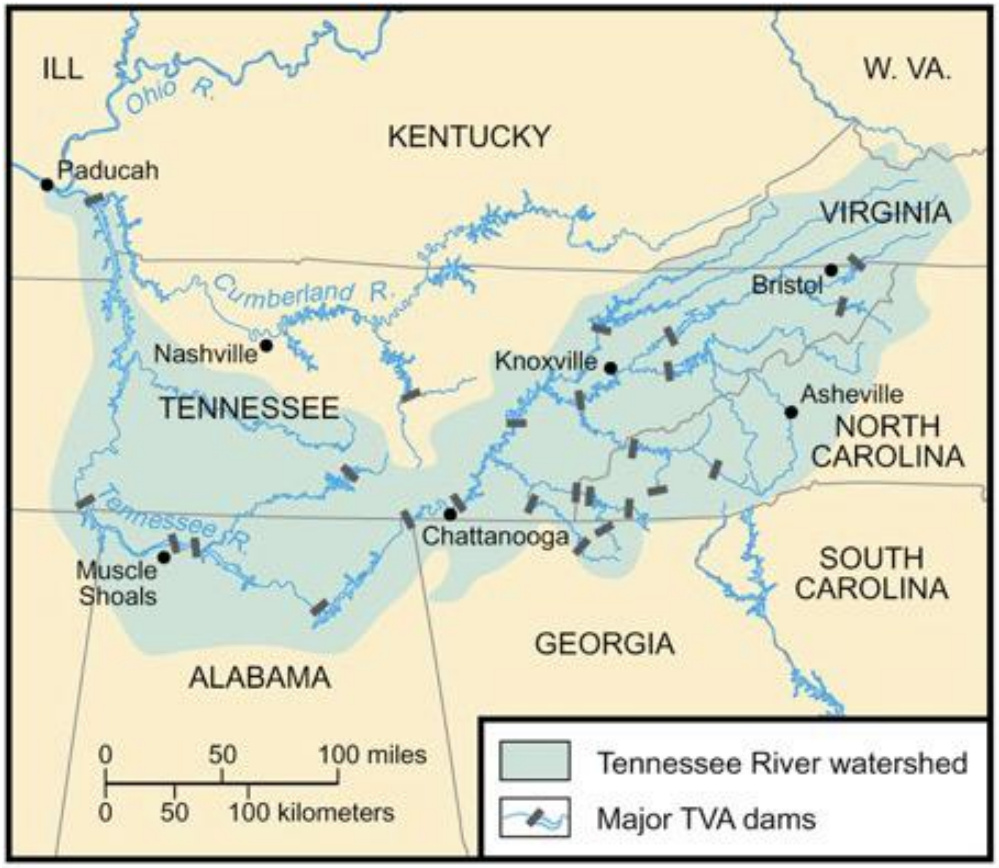
US regionalists (1930s), US rural megaprojects



THE TENNESSEE VALLEY AUTHORITY

Regional megaprojects:

- federal support
- during the Great Depression
- the middle South
- massive investments in hydroelectric dams

>> cheap power to bring manufacturing to the region

>> agglomeration
>> industrial cluster

>> place-based approach: greater polarisation than in the people-based approach

Setting the direction of rural planning

- Countryside challenges, i.e.: concern with urban sprawl, people 'colonising' the countryside, the impacts of increasing car ownership and mobility, the countryside as a consumption space, particularly for recreation and second home ownership

- 2 key policy imperatives are established:
  (1) the preservation of **agricultural land**, and
  (2) the preservation of the **countryside on aesthetic grounds** as England's greatest historical monument

Abercrombie, P. (1926). The Preservation of Rural England. *Town Planning Review, 12* (1), 5-56.

>> Sets the tone of rural planning for much of the 20th century

Setting the direction of rural planning

Themes:

- Rural as **agricultural** (became deeply entrenched following WWII)
- Rural as **picturesque** and as **heritage**
- **Preservationist ethos:**
  >> the rural to be protected

Outcomes: Post-WWII rural planning

- Increasing **urban focus** in planning theory and practice
  >> due to great urbanisation, motorisation, rural-to-urban migrations

- **Rural areas marginalised** in planning thought
  >> traditional approach – agriculture + scenic environments – considered sufficient when addressing rural areas

- Agricultural sector largely exempt from planning control
  >> planning focused on other land-uses than agriculture

Critique of rural planning (UK)

- Primacy of agricultural planning over land-use planning – with 'agricultural production at all costs' approach

- A 'no development ethos' in the British countryside since WWII:
  >> the **preservation of agricultural land** as a key rural goal
  >> a planning system orientated towards **urban development**

Curry & Owen (2009)

Consequences:
>> neglect of social and economic issues facing rural areas
>> a socially exclusive place to live

Critique of rural planning (US)

- Key trends identified
  >> the protection of **family farms**
  >> **farmland** preservation
  >> the protection of **amenity**
  >> a **minimal** approach to **socio-economic issues**
  >> an overwhelming **urban focus**

- The agricultural agenda led to an increasingly unimaginative rural planning regime:

  "Cities framed as key drivers of innovative and economic growth, with the rural constructed as the scenic backdrop or 'breadbasket'".

  (Lapping, 2006)

All this points to a need to reinvent rural planning for the 21st century

DISCUSSION:

Based on what was previously elaborated during the lecture, reflect (individually or in small groups) on the following questions and provide clear argumentation for each answer. The answers may also be placed in Brightspace's Discussion section.

1. **What were the most influential approaches to rural planning at the beginning of the 20th century in developed world (e.g., the UK, the US)? What is in the essence of these approaches?**

2. **What were the key features that were assigned to rural land in the aftermath of the Second World War and towards the end of the 20th century that blocked the proactive approach to rural development?**

Approaches to rural planning

	KEY ACTOR:
1. Public Land-Use Planning	public sector
2. Spatial or Territorial Planning	
3. Market-based Instruments	private sector
4. Community Action and Planning	civil sector
5. Countryside Management	various sectors
6. Other Projects and Programmes	supranational bodies

Gallent et al., 2015

1 Public land-use planning

- National policy
- Strategic planning for infrastructure and housing
- Development (settlement) planning
- Land-use control and other regulatory functions

>> regulatory planning

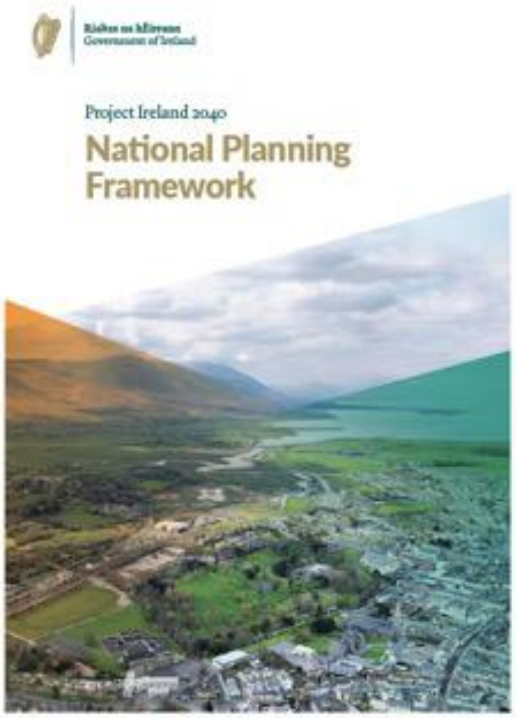
>> Example: Local Authority Development Plans, Development Management, Planning Guidelines

2 Spatial or territorial planning

- Area visioning
- Co-ordination of service investments
- Co-ordination of all public / private and third sector initiatives

>> strategic planning – place governance

>> Example (in Ireland):
National Spatial Strategy (2002);
National Planning Framework (2025);
Regional Spatial & Economic Strategies (various)



3 Market-based instruments

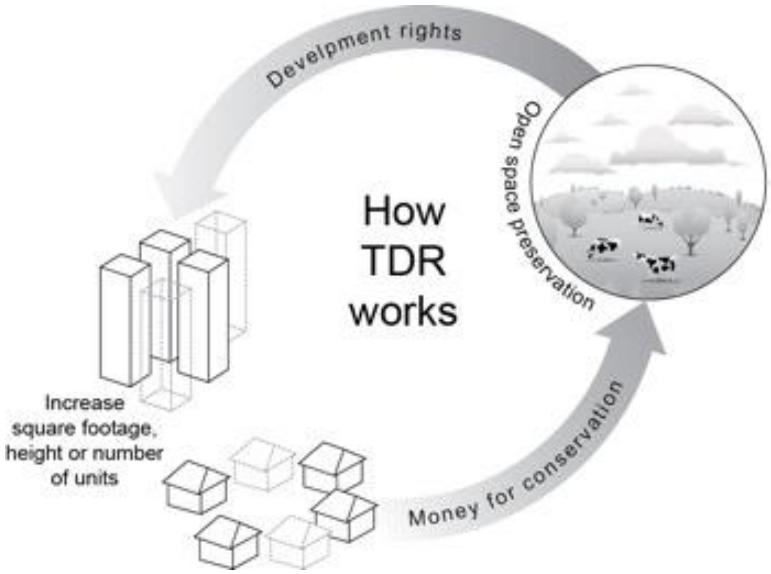
- Positive planning tool to encourage changes in behaviour
- Common in urban policy – tax incentives
- Common in the US

>> Examples:

- Planning authorities have purchased the development rights of farmland
- Tax incentives to encourage farmers to preserve agriculture land-use
- Voluntary agreements to maintain landscape in return for tax deferrals

3 Market-based instruments

- Ireland: town renewal, seaside town renewal (tax breaks, fiscal incentives)



Transfer of development rights (TDR):

a zoning technique that conserves land by **redirecting development** that would otherwise occur on the land (the sending area) to a receiving area suitable for denser development

>> TDR programmes financially compensate landowners for choosing not to develop some or all of their land

>> The landowners sell these rights to another landowner or a real estate developer for use at a different location

3 Market-based instruments

- China: Sloping Land Conservation Programme (payment for preservation of ecosystem services)

Yangliu Watershed, Yunnan Province

4 Community action and planning

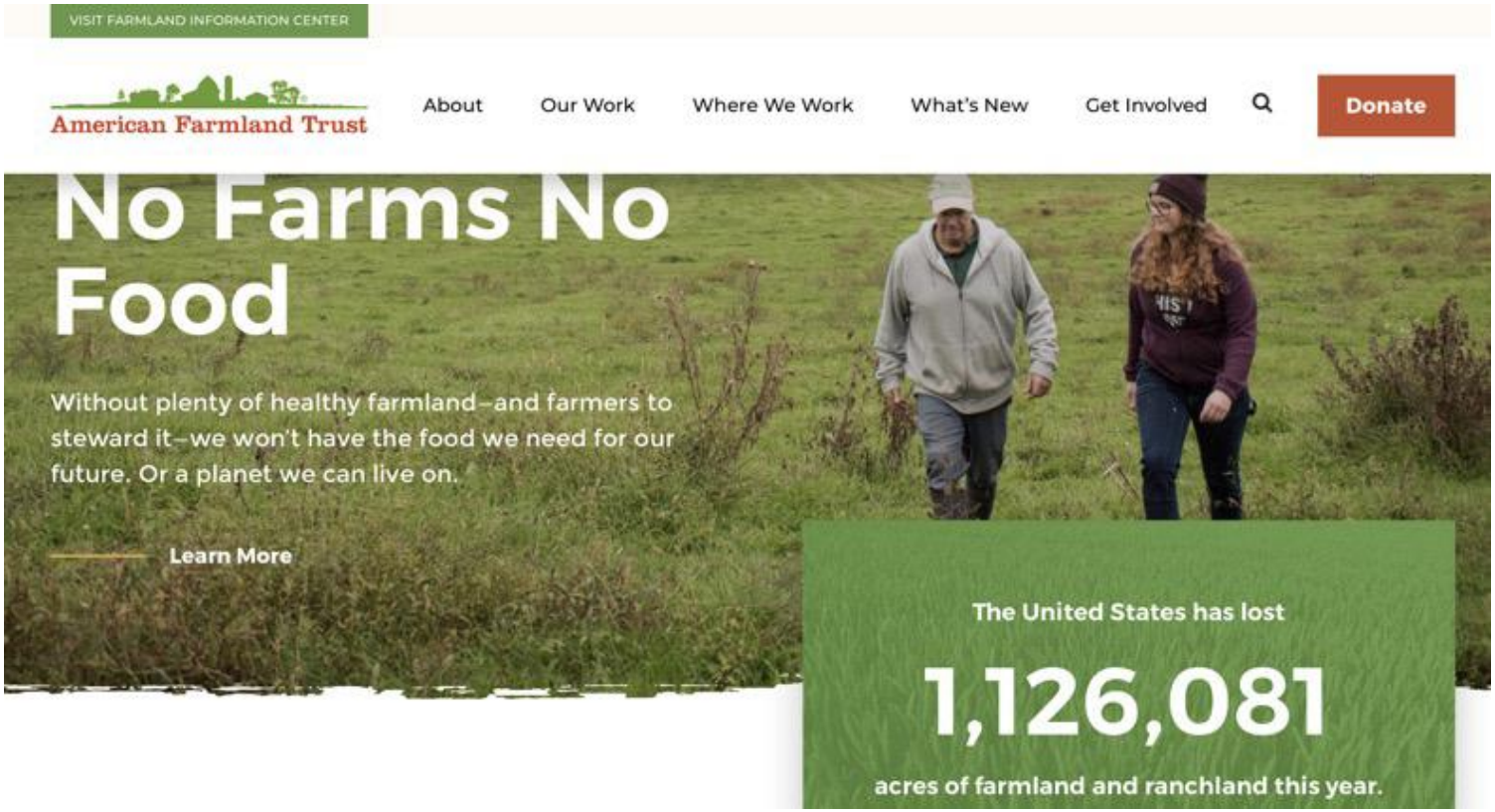
- Campaigning and lobbying
- Voluntary control of services
- Support for community development and social infrastructure
- Community visioning
- Interfacing with public and strategic planning activity

>> mix of informal activism and formalised local planning processes

>> social inclusion of certain groups and enhanced local governance

4 Community action and planning

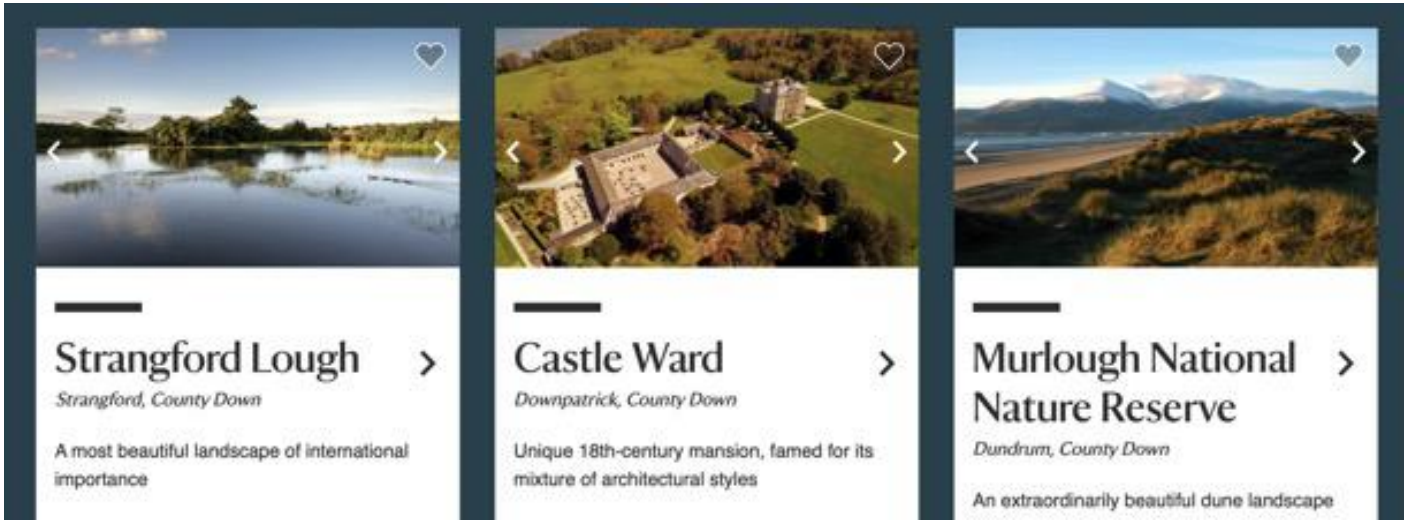
- Example: NGOs and land trusts



4 Community action and planning

- Example: National Trust (UK)

- Founded in 1895
- Protection and management of historic properties, nature reserves, coastlines
- 5+ million members



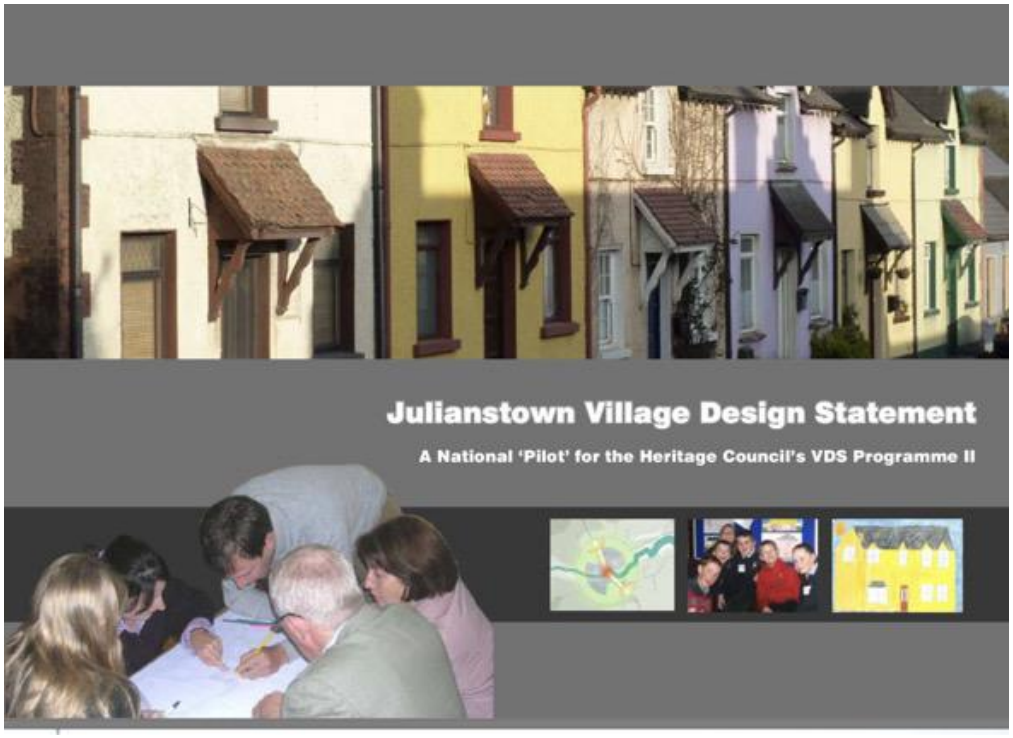
4 Community action and planning

- Example: Community Land Trusts (UK)
- Community-led approaches to:
  - Rural affordable housing
  - Renewable energy
  - Environmental assets e.g., forests

>> Good practice – Land Reform in Scotland and Scottish Land Commission

4 Community action and planning

- Example:
  Village Design Statements
- Community-led village plans
- Local participation
- Supplementary planning guidance



5 Countryside management

>> countryside: a multifunctional space with many forms of development

- local level: farming vs new ’stewardship’ (investment banks)
  e.g., deriving income from rural land assets; public ownership of land - national parks

- national level: strategies for renewable energy, mineral extraction or 'fracking’
  e.g., sectoral guidance, environmental directives

- supranational level: strategies and actions that focus on the spaces besides or between physical development
  e.g., European Landscape Convention

6 Other projects and programmes

- Supra-national directives and programmes
  e.g., Habitats Directive, UN Biosphere Reserves, UN's Food and Agriculture Organisation (FAO)
- EU Programmes – based on the Common Agricultural Policy
  e.g., LEADER, INTERREG
- Departmental or agency-based (sectoral) projects around health, education, transport etc.
- Development agency interventions
- Private sector (industrial) programmes and initiatives
  e.g., rural enterprise zones and strategic development zones

Reframing rural planning

Rural planning:

- Is broad in its scope
- Is undertaken by numerous agents
- Comprises a range of initiatives, interventions and local actions
- Goes well beyond mere land-use planning

Reframing rural planning

Rural planning is about:

- Understanding diverse ruralities
- Integrating environmental protection with social and economic dimensions of rural planning
- Planning the equitable countryside
- Reconceiving the rural environment
    - Land as a fundamental resource
    - Land as a provider of ecosystem services

Reframing rural planning

‘Grand’ challenges

- Ageing
- Food security and food systems
- Global biodiversity loss
- Rapid urbanisation
- The climate emergency

DISCUSSION:

Based on what was previously elaborated during the lecture, reflect (individually or in small groups) on the following questions and provide clear argumentation for each answer. The answers may also be placed in Brightspace's Discussion section.

1. **Given the previous approaches to rural planning and an array of mentioned tools to facilitate rural development, what would be the most useful mechanism to apply in the Chinese context of rural planning and development?**

Key takeaways

- Traditional rural planning:
  - focuses on ‘preservation’
  - neglects social and economic dimensions of rural change

- Contemporary rural planning:
  - focuses on well-being of rural dwellers
  - considers globalisation factors (e.g., urbanisation, post-carbon countryside)

- Rural planners are faced with significant demands – these will continually evolve and shift

- Policy instruments